Building a FAIR data future at the Journal of Open Humanities -- "Data Amplifying GLAM Collections: Scalable and Inclusive Data Practices"

Van Hyning, Victoria
vvh@umd.edu
University of Maryland, College of Information, United States of America

Lindquist, Thea
thea.lindquist@colorado.edu
University of Colorado Boulder, United States of America

The Journal of Open Humanities Data (JOHD) aims to be a key part of a thriving community of scholars sharing humanities data. Interest in data creation, sharing, and reuse is on the rise and has created a need for venues for data-focused publications, especially given the relevance of open data to transparent and reproducible research (Mahony, 2022). JOHD has become the largest and fastest growing data journal of its kind, and thus far has published 167 articles, many of them data papers. Emphasising the datasets' potential for reuse, these papers increase the visibility of the datasets, and thus their research impact (McGillivray et al, 2022).

Humanities subjects of interest to JOHD include, but are not limited to, Art History, Classics, History, Library Science, Linguistics, Literature, Media Studies, Modern Languages, Music and Musicology, Philosophy, Religious Studies, and more. Many articles are interdisciplinary, reflecting the multifaceted teams that enable digital humanities work. The journal features two kinds of peer reviewed publications describing humanities research objects or techniques with high potential for reuse.

Data papers contain a concise description of a humanities research object with high reuse potential. These are short highly structured narratives (1,000-1,500 words). A data paper does not replace a traditional research article, but rather complements it.

Discussion papers discuss and illustrate methods, challenges, and limitations in the creation, collection, management, access, processing, or analysis of data in humanities research, including standards and formats. These are intended to be longer narratives (3,000-5,000 words), which give authors the ability to contribute to a broader discussion.

JOHD is indexed and discoverable in more than a dozen services including Web of Science, Scopus, and Google Scholar, and is ranked by several services, including with a Scimago H-index of 3.

GLAM expansion

In 2024, JOHD's editorial team identified an opportunity to expand the representation of cultural heritage organizations and their contribution to the humanities through the publication of a special collection titled Amplifying GLAM Collections: Scalable and Inclusive Data Practices . This is the first collection to feature gallery, library, archive, and museum (GLAM) content and authors for JOHD and, to the best of our knowledge, for any other humanities data journal. Since JOHD challenges traditional concepts of the "academic article" and associated credit by stressing the multifaceted nature of data creation, sharing, and reuse, it provides an excellent platform for inviting a multiplicity of voices into the conversation, particularly cultural heritage professionals whose knowledge work constitutes a vital link in the research data lifecycle. GLAM professionals are key beneficiaries of the work presented in the special collection. The editors include Jez Cope (Data Services Lead at The British Library, and JOHD editorial board member), Victoria Van Hyning (Assistant Professor of Library Innovation, University of Maryland, College of information, and JOHD editorial board member), Eleanora Lima (Research Fellow in Digital Humanities at Trinity College, Dublin, and Associate Editor for JOHD, Thea Lindquist (Professor and Executive Director of the Center for Research Data and Digital Scholarship at the University of Colorado Boulder, and JOHD editorial board member), Deborah Thorpe (Senior Research Data Management Specialist at DANS, the Dutch national centre of expertise and repository for research data), Eleonora Zordan (Librarian in BAUM - Arts and Humanities Library at Ca' Foscari University of Venice, and copyeditor for JOHD since 2021), with additional support and guidance from JOHD editor-in-chief, Barbara McGillivray.

Our goals for this collection are rooted in our lived experiences as GLAM and academic researchers and workers ourselves, with varying degrees and kinds of experiences of creating, stewarding, and using digital GLAM data. There has

long been a tendency in academia to regard GLAM work as purely a form of service to academia, rather than as a domain that can encompass research and dataset curation. Critiques of these views can be found across humanistic disciplines and library and information science (e.g. Caswell, 2023; and Prescott and Wiggins, 2023; Brown 2018). The lamentable tendency to frame GLAM work as midwife to scholarship is especially problematic in the ever-accelerating digital age when GLAM practitioners of many kinds play a vital role in how we access and understand cultural phenomena at scale. GLAM workflows, research, and data curation–much like the many analogue curatorial work before and since the advent of digital praxis–determine what forms part of the publicly available cultural record, and the many layers of interpretation that make culture available.

Call and Response

We opened the call for papers in July 2024. This call encouraged submissions about data derived from cultural heritage collections with potential reuse value for other cultural heritage organisations or researchers, as well as scholarly and other other practitioners. This Special Collection aims to showcase innovative approaches and practical solutions to support information professionals in GLAM institutions of any size in enhancing the organisation and accessibility of their collections as data. The goal is for the papers of this Collection to empower GLAM institutions with the tools, methodologies, and knowledge necessary to navigate the digital landscape effectively. In the current digital landscape, it is imperative to ensure that the entire spectrum of institutions, regardless of size, can actively contribute to and benefit from scalable data curation practices, thus contributing to a more inclusive information landscape.

We prioritised submissions which explicitly address dataset creation and stewardship methods that can be applied in low-resource, time-stretched cultural heritage contexts. We also welcomed submission of methods papers detailing successful examples of providing access to such collections as data, and of facilitating collaborations between GLAM and academic scholars, as well as community-based practitioners and collections stewards.

37 abstracts were submitted of which 27 were discussion papers, and 10 were data papers. While data papers have been the journal's most popular peer-reviewed publication type overall, for this special collection discussion papers, which replaced full-length research papers as the journal's longer format publication type in 2024, was the option of choice. Additionally, the change in publication type options from short data papers at 1,000 words to data papers at 1,500 words was implemented for this special collection, due in part to a longer-standing trend towards submission of data papers exceeding the short data paper word limit. This situation resulted in either having to reduce the length or revise their data paper into a discussion paper, neither of which were entirely satisfactory options from the journal editors' or the authors' perspective. After publication, authors will be invited to complete a short survey reflecting on their experience with these slightly updated formats and the process overall. Our panel will share these results.

The main topics submissions addressed were web archives, infrastructure, metadata and bibliographic data, and collections as data. 18 manuscripts were submitted for review by early November, 2024. Many of those not accepted to the special collection were encouraged to submit to JOHD through the open paper track.

Authors who responded to the call include cultural heritage practitioners such as librarians, archivists, curators, and data stewards, as well as researchers, scholars, and practitioners collaborating with them. Our editorial team reflects the hoped-for range of authors for the special collections, and we are happy to report that those who responded to the call do indeed hail from GLAM (galleries, libraries, archives, and museums) organizations as well as academia. Papers submitted to the collection (currently in the peer review process) include but are not limited to the following topics:

Building DH infrastructure across jurisdictions and institutions

Crowdsourcing methods and resulting datasets

Reflections on practical knowledge organisation methodologies for libraries, archives, and cultural heritage institutions.

Accessibility and disability

Designing scalable conceptual models, knowledge graphs, ontologies, and Semantic Web solutions tailored for libraries, archives, and cultural heritage institutions.

Application of FAIR principles and CARE principles in libraries and archives for improved findability, accessibility, interoperability, and reusability.

Overcoming challenges and constraints in managing digital collections.

Implementing Linked Open Data in resource-limited environments.

Training datasets for Machine Learning and Artificial Intelligence

In this paper, we will share the final results of this special collection, which will be publis-

hed open access in early 2025. and reflect on our goals and methods for its preparation. Members of the editorial team will discuss the content of the special collection in the round—providing information about the ultimate composition oft he special collection, the methods used by the submitting authors, the spread of GLAM types, regions, and collections content represented. We will also highlight a few articles, and suggest ways in which the work of data curation and sharing might be replicable at similar orgnaizations, such as relatively small GLAM organizations with limited resources. We believe that the mission of JOHD closely aligns with the DH25 themes to increase access to the digital cultural heritage record and humanities data more broadly, by increasing the accessibility of our publications and datasets, broadening the DH tent, and by promoting data openness, reusability, and discovery.

Bibliography

Brown, Susan (2018): “Delivery Service: Gender and the Political Unconscious of Digital Humanities,” in: Bodies of Information: Intersectional Feminism and the Digital Humanities, ed. By: Wernimont, Jacqueline, Losh, Elizabeth M. Debates in Digital Humanities series, ed. Matthew K. Gold and Lauren Klein. University of Minnesota Press, 262-266. DOI: https://doi.org/10.5749/9781452963792.

Caswell, Michelle (2023): “‘The Archive’ Is Not an Archives: Acknowledging the Intellectual Contributions of Archival Studies” in: Archives: Power, Truth and Fiction, ed by: Prescott, Andrew / Wiggins, Alison, 1st ed. Oxford: Oxford University Press 21–36. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780198829324.013.0002.

Mahony, Simon (2022): “Toward Openness and Transparency to Better Facilitate Knowledge Creation,” in: Journal of the Association for Information Science and Technology 73, 10: 1-15. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1002/asi.24652.

McGillivray, Barbara / Marongiu, Paola / Pedrazzini, Nilo / Ribary, Marton / Wigdorowitz, Many / and Zordan, Eleonora (2022): “Deep Impact: A Study on the Impact of Data Papers and Datasets in the Humanities and Social Sciences,” in: Publications, 10, 4, 39. DOI: https://doi.org/10.3390/publications10040039.

Prescott, Andrew / Wiggins, Alison eds. (2023): Archives: Power, Truth and Fiction. 1st ed. Oxford: Oxford University Press. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780198829324.001.0001.